hectares of crops were damaged; 2.4 million animals had to be moved, which also affected production particularly of pigs and poultry (800,000 chickens died); 5,360 dwellings were destroyed, and 94,896 were damaged."[23] On top of the hurricanes, beginning in 2003 the island was afflicted with the worst drought in over a hundred years, causing, by the end of 2004, another $84 million in losses.[24]

Civil Society into the New Century

Despite the state's ambivalence towards independent organizations, epitomized by the crackdown on CEA and Magín, the late 1990s saw a kind of a boom in different forms of organizations and intellectual and artistic production. Some state-sponsored entities, like research institutions, became independent NGOs. Other NGOs have independent roots, or roots in different religious entities, and operate with state approval. Then there are illegal organizations, that identify clearly with opposition to the Cuban government and have either not sought legal status, or been denied it. Researchers found 350 of these organizations in 1996, and 470 in 2003. "Common threads running through these [latter] organizations," explain Díaz-Briquets and Pérez-López, "are that they are very small, command very few resources, and operate illegally … members of these organizations risk the possibility of harassment, fines, and arrests at any time for breaking the law."[25]

In the area of gender and sexuality, the new century saw significant advances. The National Center of Sexual Education (CENESEX), founded in the 1970s, had long been a progressive voice in the struggle to "undermine traditional prejudices and taboos about sexuality."[26] Under the direction of Raúl Castro's daughter and noted sexologist Mariela Castro since 2000, the Center has pioneered efforts like a "Diversity is the Norm" campaign, the right to sex-change operations under Cuba's national health system, approved in 2008, and enthusiastic participation in World Anti-Homophobia Day celebrations in 2008 and 2009. As of mid-2010, however, the government had still not implemented proposals for equal marriage rights.